A SUMMARY OF THE ENTIRE HILCHOT SHABBAT IN 14 CLASSES

The Shabbat Kitchen Part 1: Cooking (Bishul)

Class 3 of 14

Series: Laws of Shabbat — a 14-part course

Shiur: 3 of 14

Topic: The Shabbat Kitchen, Part 1 — Bishul (Cooking)

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Schedule note: Four consecutive weekly shiurim from this week.

Recap

The first two shiurim covered the positive side of Shabbat — **Zachor**: preparing for Shabbat, candles, Kiddush, the meals and Havdala. From tonight we turn to **Shamor**, the prohibited melachot — starting with one of the biggest of all: **Bishul**.

Part A — Where the Melachot Come From

The Torah mostly says only **לֹא תַעֲשֶׂה כָל מְלָאכָה** — *do no melacha*. Only two specific acts are named: **carrying** and **lighting a fire**. But "work" means different things to different people. Chazal learnt the definition from the **Mishkan**: Hashem commanded its building and then — six days you shall work, but on Shabbat rest. Whatever activities built the Mishkan are the blueprint of forbidden melacha — the **39 melachot**. Some are tied to processes no longer common today; others, like Bishul, are very practical.

Bishul in the Mishkan: the lowest of the Mishkan's roof coverings was dyed; the dye was made by boiling a paste. So the essence of Bishul is **changing a substance using fire** — not only food: heating metal until red-hot and soft is also Bishul. Tonight focuses on the kitchen.

Part B — The Basic Rules of Bishul

Yad soledet bo — the critical temperature

The Gemara defines the temperature of cooking as **יָד סוֹלֶדֶת בּוֹ** — *hot enough that the hand recoils*. The consensus of the poskim: **45°C**.

- Food placed near a fire where it can **never reach 45°C**, however long it stays, is fine — even if it gets quite warm.
- Once it **can** reach 45°C or above, it is Bishul and forbidden.
- *Aside on kashrut:* washing-up water you can hold your hands in without gloves is usually below yad soledet bo — so mix-ups in the sink are rarely a kashrut problem.

Toldot ha'esh — you don't need a flame

A common misconception is that Bishul requires fire. Anything heated by fire — a **derivative of fire** (*toldot ha'esh*) — can also cook, as long as it is at least yad soledet bo:

- A pot of soup taken off the fire is still piping hot. Placing an **egg** against its side to cook is **forbidden by the Torah** — an explicit Mishnah.
- Putting a **raw onion** into that pot before serving — forbidden by the Torah.
- An **oven** switched off before Shabbat but still hot — food may not be put in to cook.

The vessel heated directly on the fire is called a **kli rishon** (first vessel) and cooks just like the fire itself while above 45°C.

Microwaves: no fire, but they cook. Leaving aside the electrical issues, poskim debate whether it is a biblical or rabbinic prohibition — either way, we do not use a microwave on Shabbat.

Cooking in the sun — *chamah* and *toldot chamah*

The Rabbi asked the room: may you crack an egg into a frying pan and leave it in the summer sun on Shabbat? **Yes** — cooking in the sun is permitted. Bishul means cooking with fire; whatever physics says, the sun is not "fire" in the halachic sense.

The paradox: cooking in something **heated by the sun** (*toldot chamah*) — e.g. cracking an egg on a hot car, or on a frying pan that has already been baking in the sun — is **forbidden rabbinically**, because of **mar'it ayin**: an onlooker would assume the hot pan came off the fire.

- Take a **cold** pan out of the kitchen, crack the egg in the sun — **permitted**; the sun is doing the cooking.
- A pan **already hot** from the sun — **forbidden**; the hot pan is doing the cooking.
- **Chacham Ovadia Yosef**: using a **magnifying glass** to concentrate the sun's rays on water is permitted — it is still the sun's rays doing the cooking, even well above 45°C.
- Q: Is melting a solid into a liquid (or the reverse) a problem? — Not a Bishul problem.

The solar water heater (*dud shemesh*)

Very common in Israel. When you open the hot tap, cold water flows into the tank and is heated by the hot water already there — a *toldot chamah*, seemingly forbidden. Yet the halacha (Chacham Ovadia and other poskim) is that a purely **manual** dud shemesh **may be used** on Shabbat:

- It is **gerama** — an indirect result — of something only rabbinically forbidden.
- It is a **pesik reisha** one does not intend.

If opening the tap triggers **electric** heating, it is forbidden. (The Rabbi's family used one in Israel on Shabbat.)

Part C — Kli Rishon and Kli Sheni

Pour soup from the pot (*kli rishon*) into a bowl and the bowl is a **kli sheni** — twice removed from the fire. The Gemara is explicit: **כְּלִי שֵׁנִי אֵינוֹ מְבַשֵּׁל** — *a kli sheni does not cook*, even above 45°C. The walls of the pot that stood on the fire are part of the cooking process; the bowl's walls never were.

Why then do some people pour into a third vessel?

1. **Mechzei ke'mevashel** — it *looks* like cooking to an onlooker (Tosafot's reading of the Gemara).

2. The Mishnah lists some **very tender foods** that cook even in a kli sheni — e.g. **salted herring**. Since we no longer know exactly which foods are like this, a blanket stringency applies.

Practice	Kli sheni
Ashkenazim	Do not put raw food in a kli sheni (for both reasons); use a kli shlishi
Sephardim	Most foods may be put in a kli sheni; avoid only the known tender foods — salted fish such as herring, egg, and according to some lemon

Making tea

The urn is a **kli rishon**; a cup filled from it is a **kli sheni**.

- **Ashkenazim:** pour from the urn into a cup, then into a second cup (*kli shlishi*), and only then add the tea bag or leaves.
- **Sephardim (strict halacha — Chacham Ovadia):** one may put a tea bag into the **first cup** (kli sheni).
- **Never** pour from the urn directly onto a tea bag or leaves already in the cup — that is **iruy kli rishon**, pouring from a kli rishon, which has a status close to the kli rishon itself.
- Since tea leaves are tender, it is **praiseworthy** to use a kli shlishi — or to pour the hot water from the first cup onto the tea bag in a second cup. Those who don't need not be objected to.
- **Tea essence** (already-processed concentrate) — fine even from the urn.

Instant coffee, milk

- **Instant coffee** (e.g. Nescafé) — already processed, so you may pour **directly from the urn** onto the granules.
- **Milk** into a kli sheni — fine for Sephardim; it is pasteurised, so many Ashkenazim also permit it.
- Q: Is there a dyeing problem when milk colours the coffee? — No; there is no *tzove'a* with food and drink.
- Q: Must the cup be dry? — If the drops in it are water that was already boiled (e.g. your second coffee), certainly fine. If just rinsed with cold water, many say it is fine (only a few drops); some prefer to dry it.

Davar gush — hot solids

Some argue the kli sheni leniency applies only to **liquids**; a hot **solid** (a boiled potato, a kugel) keeps its heat however many times it is moved, and could still cook spices or salt sprinkled on it. Hence many Ashkenazim avoid raw spices on hot kugel even on the third or fourth plate. **Sephardim do not hold this stringency** — a solid moved onto a plate is a kli sheni like a liquid.

Part D — Ein Bishul Achar Bishul

אֵין בְּשׁוּל אַחַר בְּשׁוּל — once something is **fully cooked**, it cannot be cooked further.

Bishul (cooking) vs Afiyah (baking)

- **Bishul** — changing a substance with fire **and water** (a pot of soup).
- **Afiyah** — changing it with fire **without water** (baking challah, roasting).

Is cooking something that was baked (or baking something that was cooked) a new melacha? The Shulchan Aruch brings both views; the main view is the second — **it is permitted**: once fully processed in

one way, the other way is not a new Bishul. Chacham Ovadia notes it is good to be stringent where easy.

- Putting **challah into a pot of soup** off the fire — permitted for Sephardim.
- Taking **cooked meat** out of soup and putting it on a hotplate (dry heat) — permitted.
- **Ashkenazim** are stringent: a kli shlishi, since already-cooked food is even more tender.

Croutons in soup

The croutons are baked; soup is bishul — so for Sephardim, croutons may go into a bowl of soup (kli sheni). For Ashkenazim, if the soup was served with a **ladle**, the ladle is itself a vessel, so the bowl is already a kli shlishi — permitted for them too. Only when pouring directly from the pot would they need a further bowl.

Turkish (black) coffee

The grounds are **roasted** (dry heat), so strictly one may pour from the urn directly. In practice **Chacham Ovadia advises against it** — not every grain is fully roasted, so one may be cooking something for the first time. Preferably use a kli sheni.

Barbecued meat; toast

- **Barbecued meat** (dry heat) may be put into a pot of soup that is off the fire.
- **Toast:** baked challah may be put directly on a (permitted) hotplate or on top of the urn — even if it darkens. It is already fully baked. (The status of hotplates comes next week.)

Part E — Reheating, and Speeding Up Cooking

Solids vs liquids

- **Solids** (e.g. a schnitzel), once fully cooked, may be reheated even after they have cooled — the main purpose of cooking a solid is to make it edible, and it remains so.
- **Liquids**, once cooled, **may not be reheated** to above yad soledet bo — the main purpose of heating a liquid is that it be hot, so once cold it is subject to Bishul again.

So: soup taken off the hotplate to serve guests, once it has cooled below 45°C, may not go back on.

Here the Ashkenazim are more lenient: as long as the liquid is still **warm** (even 20–25°C), they may return it. For Sephardim, once below yad soledet bo it may not be reheated.

What counts as "fully cooked"?

Food is fully cooked when it is **edible as it is** — "if I wanted to eat it now, I would." A cholent that is edible but will get tastier overnight (*mitztamek ve'yafeh lo*) is already fully cooked.

Bones: if the dish is cooked but the bones are not yet soft, returning it to the fire would finish cooking the bones. The poskim say it depends: if you eat the bones, it is forbidden; if you don't, it is permitted.

Megis — speeding up cooking

Accelerating cooking — e.g. turning up the flame under half-cooked food — is **Bishul from the Torah**. Practical applications:

- **Lifting the lid:** the cholent went on an hour before Shabbat; two hours in, you lift the lid and see it needs another half hour. You **may not put the lid back** — that concentrates the heat and speeds up

cooking.

- **Stirring** food that is not fully cooked — forbidden, even after taking it off the fire, since stirring speeds up cooking.
- **Stirring on the fire** — forbidden even if fully cooked (it looks like cooking, and adds a qualitative change).
- **Ladling** is "a mini-stir": from food not fully cooked, don't even take out a portion. Some forbid ladling even fully cooked food while it is on the fire.
- **Best practice:** take the pot **off** the fire, serve, then return it (to a permitted hotplate or blech).

Left for next week: eating in a home where these laws are not kept — may one eat the food?

Dvar Torah — Parashat Toldot: The Cost of Not Communicating

Rivka suffers in pregnancy and goes to seek counsel — not from her husband Yitzchak or her father-in-law Avraham, the greatest people of the age, but from **Shem**, son of Noach. Shem tells her she carries twins: one righteous, one wicked. Later, when Yitzchak plans to bless Esav, Rivka does not speak to him — she has Yaakov disguise himself instead. The consequences: Esav's hatred, Yaakov's flight for 22 years, and Rivka never seeing her beloved son again.

The **Netziv** (Rav Naftali Tzvi Yehuda Berlin, 19th-century Lithuania) explains — "if he hadn't said it, I wouldn't dare" — that Yitzchak and Rivka's relationship differed from that of Avraham and Sarah or Yaakov and Rachel. From their first meeting — Rivka saw Yitzchak in prayer and **fell from her camel** — she was in awe of him, and never able to open up to him. So she went to Shem rather than to Yitzchak; and having done so, could not later tell him of the prophecy. Hence the whole drama of the blessings.

The lesson for our own lives: the importance of **communication and dialogue**. Had they been able to talk, things would have turned out very differently.

Summary

- **Bishul** = changing a substance with fire; the threshold is **yad soledet bo, 45°C**.
- A **kli rishon** (and anything heated by fire) cooks like fire itself — no flame needed.
- **Sun**: permitted; **something heated by the sun**: rabbinically forbidden. A manual **dud shemesh** is permitted.
- **Kli sheni** does not cook — Sephardim may use it for most foods (not herring, egg, lemon); Ashkenazim use a kli shlishi.
- **Tea:** never pour from the urn onto the tea bag; Sephardim may add it to the first cup, a second cup is preferable. **Instant coffee:** directly from the urn.
- **Ein bishul achar bishul**; cooking after baking and vice versa permitted for Sephardim (croutons, toast, challah in soup).
- **Cooled liquids** may not be reheated (Sephardim: below 45°C); solids may.
- Don't **stir**, re-cover or ladle food that is not fully cooked; take pots off the fire to serve.

Coming Up

Shiur 4 — 13 November: The Shabbat Kitchen, Part 2

- *She'hiyah* — leaving food on the fire from before Shabbat

- *Hazara* — returning food to the fire on Shabbat
- *Hatmana* — insulating food, e.g. wrapping in a towel
- Hotplates and blechs

B'Ezrat Hashem

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